EMAIL WRITING EXERCISES WITH ANSWERS

Sessions 19, 20 & 21: Language Skills for Engineers

Exercise 1: Ordering Email Components

Instructions: The components of this email to Dr. Sunil have been scrambled. Put them in the correct order.

Answer:

The correct order of email component is as follows:

1. Subject Line (specific and clear about the purpose)
2. Greeting (Dear Dr. Sunil, or Hi Dr. Sunil,)
3. Opening Line (state your purpose early - why you're writing)
4. Body Paragraph (provide supporting details and context)
5. Call to Action (a clear instruction on what you need the recipient to do)
6. Closing (brief sign-off like 'Thank you' or 'I appreciate your help')
7. Signature (your full name, student ID, and any relevant contact details)

Exercise 2: Complete the Sentences

Instructions: Complete each sentence by choosing the option in brackets that fits best, or write your own if none quite fit.

Answer:

1. So far, we've completed the circuit testing phase.

We've finished all the initial testing work and are ready to move on to the next steps.

2. We're currently finalizing the enclosure design, with just a few details left.

The design is almost done. We're just working through the last few tweaks before it's ready.

3. One thing that's holding us up is the missing part shipment.

We're waiting on parts to arrive, and they haven't gotten here yet, which is slowing us down.

4. This may delay our overall timeline by a couple of days.

Because of this hold-up, we'll probably need to push back our deadline slightly.

5. Would any of the following work for you: Tuesday at 2 PM?

I'm suggesting a specific time and want to know if it works with your schedule.

6. I wanted to set up a quick call to discuss the project proposal.

I'm reaching out because I'd like to have a brief conversation with you about our project.

7. Great, that time works for me. I'll add it to my calendar.

I'm confirming that Tuesday at 2 PM is good for me and I'm noting it down.

8. Something's come up, so would it be possible to reschedule our meeting?

An unexpected situation has come up on my end, and I need to ask if we can move our meeting to a different time.

9. Just a heads-up, the deadline is coming up fast.

I wanted to give you a friendly reminder that we don't have much time left before this is due.

10. If you have any questions before then, feel free to reach out.

Don't hesitate to get in touch with me if you need anything clarified.

Exercise 3: Identify the Email Type

Instructions: Identify the type of email for each short scenario: Cold Email, General Interest/Networking, Follow-Up, Complaint, Apology, Confirmation, or Transactional.

Answer:

1. My name is Alekhya, a first-year ECE student. I wanted to ask if you have any openings in your lab.

This is a Cold Email. Alekhya is reaching out to someone she doesn't know yet, introducing herself and asking about opportunities.

2. Your order has been confirmed and is being processed.

This is a Transactional Email. It's an automated message confirming that a purchase went through.

3. I emailed last week about joining your lab — just checking if you've had a chance to consider it.

This is a Follow-Up Email. The sender is checking in on a previous message that hasn't been answered yet.

4. I was charged a $200 late fee, but my payment was on time. Could you correct this?

This is a Complaint Email. Someone is pointing out a problem and asking for it to be fixed.

5. Would you be open to a quick 15-minute call about how you got started in biomedical engineering?

This is a General Interest/Networking Email. The sender is asking for advice and a conversation, not pushing for a specific opportunity.

6. Confirming our meeting this Thursday at 2 PM — let me know if anything changes.

This is a Confirmation Email. The sender is putting the details of an already-scheduled meeting in writing so both people are on the same page.

7. I'm sorry I missed our meeting yesterday. I should have given you a heads-up.

This is an Apology Email. The sender is acknowledging a mistake and taking responsibility for it.

8. Your registration has been confirmed. Confirmation #: REG-88213.

This is a Transactional Email. It's an automated system-generated message with confirmation details.

9. I saw that your company sponsors capstone projects. I'd love to explore that for our team.

This is a Cold Email. The sender is making an unsolicited reach-out about a potential opportunity with a company they don't currently work with.

Exercise 4: Professional Email Formatting

Instructions: Answer the following questions about formatting professional emails.

Answer:

1. Given: a scenario (emailing a coworker about a late deliverable, with your manager needing visibility), decide who goes in To vs. Cc.

Put your coworker in the To field since they're the main person you're emailing about the deliverable. Add your manager to the CC line so they're kept in the loop but the message is directed at your coworker. This way, your manager sees what's being discussed without it seeming like you're going around your coworker or throwing them under the bus.

2. Write a closing line that gives the reader a clear next step, for an email requesting feedback on a draft.

Could you take a look and send me your thoughts by the end of day Friday? I'd really appreciate any comments you have so I can make improvements. Or: Let me know if you have any questions about the draft, and feel free to reach out if you'd like to discuss anything in person.

3. Take this run-on sentence and break it into two clearly separated ideas:

Original: I wanted to let you know that I finished the report but I also had a question about the data and also I was wondering if we could meet this week.

Revised:

I wanted to let you know that I've finished the report. I did have a quick question about the data though - could we find time to meet this week to go over it?

This breaks it into two separate thoughts: (1) the report is done, and (2) there's a question that needs discussion. It's much easier to read this way, and the reader understands what you need without getting lost in a bunch of clauses.